

Medal rush in Gulmarg

The picturesque Kongdoori slopes in Jammu & Kashmir hosting the second leg of the 2025 Khelo India Winter Games is one of the **many strides** that India has made towards becoming a prominent snow sports destination.

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In the last decade or so, Indian sport has undergone a significant transformation due to heavy investment from the public and private sectors. However, this progress has yet to fully extend to winter sports. With approximately 3,000 kilometres (1,864 miles) of mountain ranges, India has always had the potential to be a leader in winter sports, but a lack of robust governance and established tradition has hindered its progress for years.

With the successful completion of the second leg of the Khelo India Winter Games (KIWG) 2025 on the picturesque Kongdoori slopes in Gulmarg, Jammu & Kashmir, it appears India is finally making strides towards becoming a prominent snow sports destination. More than 350 athletes from across the country participated in the second leg of the fifth edition of the KIWG from March 9-12. They competed in four snow disciplines: Alpine Skiing, Nordic Skiing, Ski Mountaineering (SkiMo), and Snowboarding; all of which are Olympic sports.

Riding a wave of awareness

Despite overcast skies, almost zero visibility, and avalanche warnings, participants and organisers persevered, ensuring the events continued on the foothills of the majestic Pir Panjal range. The collaborative event, organised by the Sports Authority of India (SAI) and the Jammu & Kashmir Sports Council, generated significant excitement throughout the valley, exhibited by the pervasive presence of promotional materials from Srinagar airport to the Gulmarg ski resort.

With increased participation in each edition, KIWG is successfully raising awareness of winter sports in the country. Even the tourists flocking to the famous hill station were captivated by the proceedings. Despite the increased attention, winter sports in general are still in a nascent stage in the country.

As of now, only 16 Indian athletes have participated in the Winter Olympics across 11 editions, and the nation still awaits its first podium finish.

Farhat Naik, the KIWG competition director for snowboarding and India's national snowboarding coach, believes financial support is the key for Indian athletes to achieve

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